

Fun on the run

Mobile entertainment in India is really heating up. Find out where all the action lies and what is in store for us in the years to come

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India has probably added its 500 millionth mobile subscriber! That's quite a feat considering we're still hailed as an developing country. Over time the mobile telephony landscape has changed and mobile phones are not just merely used for voice calling. They form the framework through which entertainment content is delivered to the masses. Lately the action is heating up quite a bit in this space with a number of innovative offerings from various members of the mobile content eco-system. Going by the numbers, it looks like our appetite for entertainment is limitless. Just a small taste of this can be evinced by the fact that even caller tunes (technically known as CRBT - caller ring back tones) is apparently a home grown concept.

It won't be long before almost every Indian holds a mobile device. The sheer number of users in the country is very high as a function of the population. We have close to 500 million subscribers and our population is 1.1 billion. This creates a large eco-system for entertainment content providers to constantly innovate and come up with interesting offerings to catch the attention of users. The ultimate winner is the consumer who can enjoy the various offerings.

"In this age of convergence, the prominent growth driver in this sector is the consumers' desire of getting more from their mobile phones. Content is definitely the king in the mobile VAS segment," opines Simone, Co-CEO of Buongiorno.

"While GPRS usage is getting more and more popular, the number is still low, say 35 million users across the country who access mobile internet, WAP and premium content on their phone," says Rajiv Hiranandani co-founder of Mobie2Win, a leading mobile entertainment company.

The story so far...

According to Hiranandani, what is available to the consumer right now is a variety of data and entertainment services across various platforms. You have the SMS platform, the WAP platform, and the voice platform. Additionally, entertainment applications are inbuilt into handsets. You can access subscription services that deliver alerts in the form of Jokes, Cricket updates, Stock alerts, Edutainment, etc. Basically, a variety of information options are offered by an operator to consumers over SMS. "The basic premise is that a lot of information available out there on other forms of media can also be made available to the consumer via text messaging," adds Rajiv. This forms the basis of infotainment.

There are many players providing this content via operators. Mauj.com, hungama.com and mobile2win.com are just some of the players. Alert services may not necessarily be operator bound. Even third-party content creators can deliver this data. One way in which this can happen is by short code which of course has to be live. So when the consumer sends a keyword via

short code to the content provider, the relevant piece of information is sent back to the consumer along with other options as promotional material. The WAP platform that came into existence some time ago is now gaining popularity with the masses. Still, with full-fledged web browsers built into smartphones of today, soon you may no longer need mobile optimised sites. However, the opportunities for entertainment for WAP come along with imagery. Basic wallpapers to MMS content, themes, mobile games, casual games, multiplayer games, are found on direct to consumer mobile sites such as Handango.com, Zedge.com or PhoneyTunes.com.

